

Romans 7–8: From Self-Dependence to Christ-Dependence

Introduction

Romans 7:14–25 has been interpreted in different ways throughout Christian history. Some understand Paul to be describing the experience of an unbeliever under the law, while others understand the passage as describing the experience of a believer struggling with indwelling sin. I strongly believe the latter interpretation best fits Paul's language and the context of Romans 6–8.

Romans 7:14–25 is therefore understood here as the experience of a genuine believer who has discovered the reality of indwelling sin but has not yet learned to rely fully upon the power of the Holy Spirit. The passage serves as God's lesson in self-dependence and its failure, bringing the believer to the realization that victory cannot be achieved through the strength of the flesh but through dependence upon Christ and the power of the Holy Spirit.

¹ Unless otherwise noted, all Scripture quotations in this paper are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB).

I. The Discovery of a New Desire (Romans 7:15–22)

A. The Believer Genuinely Desires Holiness

“I do not understand what I do. For what I want to do, I do not do. But what I hate, I do.” — Romans 7:15

“I know that nothing good lives in me, that is, in my flesh; for I have the desire to do what is good, but I cannot carry it out.” — Romans 7:18

“For in my inner being I delight in God's law.” — Romans 7:22

The person described by Paul does not merely recognize that God's law is good; he *delights* in it and genuinely desires to do what is right.

The believer now:

- loves God's Word,
- desires obedience,
- hates sin,
- longs to please Christ.

Practical Application

A genuine hatred of sin and a desire for holiness are consistent with spiritual life.

The presence of spiritual struggle does not by itself prove spiritual death. For the believer, the struggle can reveal the conflict between the desire to obey God and the continuing presence of indwelling sin.

II. The Discovery of Indwelling Sin (Romans 7:17–20)

A. The Believer Discovers Another Principle at Work

“In that case, it is no longer I who do it, but it is sin living in me.” — Romans 7:17

The Christian soon discovers that conversion does not eradicate the flesh.

Though justified and accepted in Christ:

- sinful desires remain,
- temptations remain,
- weaknesses remain,
- the flesh remains.

Paul's language does not excuse sin. Instead, it exposes the continuing power of sin within the believer and the believer's inability to overcome it through self-effort.

Supporting Scriptures

- Galatians 5:17
- 1 John 1:8
- James 3:2

Practical Application

Spiritual growth begins when we stop being surprised by the presence of the flesh and begin agreeing with God's diagnosis of it.

III. The Failure of Self-Effort (Romans 7:18–23)

A. Good Intentions Are Not Enough

“For I do not do the good I want to do. Instead, I keep on doing the evil I do not want to do.” — Romans 7:19

The believer discovers:

- knowledge is not enough,

- determination is not enough,
- resolutions are not enough,
- self-discipline alone is not enough.

The Great Lesson

The flesh cannot overcome the flesh.

One may:

- make promises,
- set goals,
- rededicate himself,
- increase religious activity,

yet still experience defeat.

The problem is not that God's law is inadequate. Paul has already declared that the law is spiritual, holy, righteous, and good. The problem is the weakness of the flesh.

Practical Application

God allows us to discover our weakness so that we cease trusting in ourselves and learn to depend upon Him.

IV. The Cry of Self-Despair (Romans 7:24)

“What a wretched man I am! Who will rescue me from this body of death?” — Romans 7:24

A. The Turning Point

Notice that Paul does not ask:

“What shall deliver me?”

but:

“Who will rescue me?”

His focus finally shifts away from himself and toward a Deliverer.

Practical Application

Deliverance begins when we stop looking to ourselves as the source of victory and start looking to Christ.

The Christian life is not improved self-effort.

It is dependence upon a Person.

V. The Discovery of Christ's Sufficiency (Romans 7:25)

“Thanks be to God, through Jesus Christ our Lord!” — Romans 7:25

A. The Answer Is Christ

Paul's answer to the dilemma of Romans 7 is not greater effort but a greater Deliverer.

Victory is not found in:

- stronger willpower,
- deeper determination,
- greater religious effort.

Victory is found in Christ.

Supporting Scriptures

- John 15:5
- Galatians 2:20
- Philippians 4:13

Practical Application

The believer's confidence shifts from self to Christ.

VI. The Principle of Faith in Sanctification

A. Justification and Sanctification Both Depend Upon Grace

One of the great lessons of Romans 7 is that the believer learns in sanctification the same basic principle of dependence upon Christ that characterized his justification: righteousness and spiritual life cannot be produced by human self-effort.

Before salvation, the sinner must acknowledge:

“I cannot save myself.”

No amount of morality, religion, or law-keeping can produce righteousness before God.

“Therefore no one will be justified in His sight by works of the law.” — Romans 3:20

The sinner abandons confidence in himself and rests entirely upon Christ's finished work.

Salvation is received by grace through faith.

B. The Believer Must Learn a Similar Lesson

After conversion, many believers unknowingly return to self-dependence. Having trusted Christ for justification, they attempt to pursue sanctification primarily through willpower and determination.

Romans 7 exposes the frustration of that approach.

The believer learns:

- I cannot overcome sin by my own strength.
- I cannot produce holiness through determination.
- I cannot defeat the flesh through the flesh.

The lesson of Romans 7 is not merely that man sins; it is that self-reliance cannot produce the righteousness God desires.

C. Sanctification Is Lived by Faith

Just as justification requires abandoning confidence in personal righteousness, sanctification requires abandoning confidence in personal strength.

The Christian life is not self-improvement but Christ-dependence.

Paul asks:

“After starting in the Spirit, are you now finishing in the flesh?” — Galatians 3:3

And again:

“Therefore, just as you received Christ Jesus the Lord, walk in Him.” — Colossians 2:6

Practical Application

The Christian life is not sustained by greater self-reliance but by greater dependence upon Christ.

Justification teaches us to trust Christ for righteousness.

Sanctification teaches us to depend upon Christ for strength to live the Christian life.

In both cases, grace is God's provision rather than something produced by human effort.

VII. The Life of the Spirit (Romans 8)

A. The Spirit Accomplishes What Self-Effort Cannot

Romans 7 reveals the futility of self-dependence.

Romans 8 reveals God's provision through the Holy Spirit.

“Therefore, there is now no condemnation for those who are in Christ Jesus. For in Christ Jesus the law of the Spirit of life set you free from the law of sin and death.” — Romans 8:1–2

Paul does not leave the believer in Romans 7. He moves directly into the freedom and provision of Romans 8.

“So that the righteous standard of the law might be fulfilled in us, who do not walk according to the flesh but according to the Spirit.” — Romans 8:4

Supporting Scriptures

- Galatians 5:16
- 2 Corinthians 3:18
- Ephesians 3:16

Practical Application

The Christian life is lived by:

- abiding in Christ,
- walking in the Spirit,
- depending upon God's power.

VIII. The Ongoing Reality of the Christian Life

A. The Flesh Remains

The New Testament does not teach that believers achieve sinless perfection in this present life.

“If we say we have no sin, we deceive ourselves, and the truth is not in us.” — 1 John 1:8

The presence of remaining sin does not mean that the believer is outside Christ. It means that sanctification remains an ongoing work of God's grace.

B. The Spirit Remains

The believer is never left to fight alone.

“So I say, walk by the Spirit, and you will not gratify the desires of the flesh.” — Galatians 5:16

Practical Application

The mature Christian is not one who has eliminated every struggle with sin.

The mature Christian is one who increasingly depends upon the Holy Spirit rather than upon himself.

Conclusion

Romans 7 teaches: *“I cannot.”*

Romans 8 teaches: *“Christ can.”*

The purpose of Romans 7 is not to leave the believer in defeat, but to bring him to the end of self-reliance so that he may discover the sufficiency of Christ and the power of the indwelling Spirit.

The same God who justifies the sinner also sanctifies the believer. The sinner is justified by abandoning confidence in his own righteousness and trusting Christ alone. Likewise, the believer grows in holiness by abandoning confidence in his own strength and depending upon Christ through the indwelling Holy Spirit.

As Paul writes:

“Therefore, just as you received Christ Jesus the Lord, walk in Him.” — Colossians 2:6

True faith produces fruit, but not through self-effort. The fruit of the Christian life is produced by the Holy Spirit as the believer walks by faith and depends upon Christ. Sanctification is not merely the flesh trying harder; it is the believer yielding to Christ and walking in the power of the Spirit.

The Holy Spirit does not eliminate the believer's responsibility. Scripture calls the Christian to walk, yield, put to death the deeds of the body, and set his mind on the things of the Spirit. Christian dependence is therefore not passive resignation but active faith.

As we look away from ourselves and depend upon Christ, the Spirit enables us to overcome the desires of the flesh. Paul's own words provide an example of this growing dependence:

“I have learned to be content regardless of my circumstances. I know how to live humbly, and I know how to abound. I have learned the secret of being content in every situation, whether I am well fed or hungry, whether I am living in abundance or in need. I can do all things through Christ who gives me strength.” — Philippians 4:11–13

Romans 7 reveals our inability; Romans 8 reveals God's provision.

The Christian life begins, continues, and ends with God's grace. The believer's hope is not found in the improvement of the flesh, but in the sufficiency of Christ, who is our righteousness, our strength, and our victory.